

TAKING STEPS TOWARD INDEPENDENCE

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Identify and acknowledge fears that inhibit independent actions.
2. Identify events in the past that have taught fear rather than confidence.
3. List steps that can be taken to begin to be more independent.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Low Self-Esteem

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The client will be asked to examine his/her history to identify circumstances that contributed to living a life of fear and dependence on others. Give the client support for revealing painful events that have nurtured fear, but also encourage growth in taking steps toward learning to overcome fear and live more independently.

TAKING STEPS TOWARD INDEPENDENCE

Fear and lack of confidence can thwart the normal development of independence. You may look to others to make decisions for you while you seek to please them in any possible way, even if it means taking over activities that clearly belong as the responsibility of others. Explore your fears and ways to overcome those fears by increasing independent actions.

1. **Fear of Disappointing Others:** This is a common fear that inhibits the growth of independence. Describe circumstances in your past that could have taught you to expect that you will disappoint others when you make a decision to act.

2. **Fear of Failure:** Describe incidents in your past that contribute to your expectation of failure when you take independent action.

3. **Fear of Abandonment:** What family or social circumstances have caused you to fear that others will leave you alone if you do not constantly try to please them?

4. **Independent Actions:** List actions you can take that will help you overcome your fears and increase your independence. Give a date for implementation.

Action

Date

1)		
2)		
3)		